CS 301R · CONTRIBUTOR READINESS

Could Someone Join This?

Project _____

Tester _____

Tag or commit _____

Every newcomer to any project asks the same five questions, whether it's a new hire's first week on a team, a first-time contributor to an open-source library, or you, eight months from now, reopening your own code. A project that answers them on purpose gets joined. One that answers them by accident mostly gets left.

As a self-check: mark your own project honestly. Every *stall* or *fail* goes on your launch punch list.

As a test script: a tester who has never seen the project works through it cold, from the repository alone, and marks what happened.

The five newcomer needs *For each: look where a newcomer would, hold it to the bar, mark one result, and say why in a line*

NEED	WHERE A NEWCOMER LOOKS	THE BAR	RESULT	WHY
1 What is this? *New hire: "what does this team build?"*	The README's first screen: what it does, for whom, its status	After 60 seconds, the tester explains it back in one sentence, and the status matches what runs	☐ pass ☐ stall ☐ fail	
2 Am I welcome? *New hire: "can I ask questions here?"*	CONTRIBUTING's tone, the code of conduct, how past issues and pull requests were answered	The small signals say yes: a warm first line, a real reporting contact, outside questions answered kindly	☐ pass ☐ stall ☐ fail	
3 How do I start? *New hire: "how do I get it running?"*	The setup guide, followed exactly, then the test command	Running, with tests passing, from the docs alone; nothing the tester had to guess	☐ pass ☐ stall ☐ fail	
4 Where do I start? *New hire: "what's my first task?"*	Issues labeled *good first issue*, the roadmap	The tester picks a starter issue and finds the code to change without asking anyone	☐ pass ☐ stall ☐ fail	
5 Will anyone respond? *New hire: "who reviews my work, and when?"*	The communication norms; how long recent issues and pull requests waited	A stated response time the record shows is being kept, and a named place to ask	☐ pass ☐ stall ☐ fail	

Pass: met the bar from the docs alone. **Stall:** got there, but only by guessing, searching, or working around something. **Fail:** couldn't get there.

Under the hood *The author checks these; a tester can confirm any of them*

☐	**A newcomer can tell if they broke something:** at least one automated test exercises the core logic, runs with the command the setup guide names, and passes	the test command, on the tagged version
☐	**What's broken is written down:** throwaway corners, deliberate cuts, and open audit findings, each with its issue	the known-issues log, linked from the README
☐	**The map matches the territory:** the architecture overview describes what was built, not what was planned	the architecture overview
☐	**There's somewhere to go next:** the roadmap says what a newcomer would do first, and claims nothing the code can't support	the roadmap
☐	**Every promise is one you'll keep:** response times and review norms you can actually meet after the term ends	the communication norms

Since the audit *Authors: before the test, write the two stalls that most stopped your last auditor. Tester: check each one.*

1 _____ ☐ fixed ☐ logged in known issues ☐ still there

2 _____ ☐ fixed ☐ logged in known issues ☐ still there

If someone found this project in a few months, with no one to ask, what would stop them first?

Tester's signature _____ Received by the authors (initials) _____

Fix it or log it. Everything a tester marked *stall* or *fail* is either fixed or written into the known-issues log. Silence is the only failure.